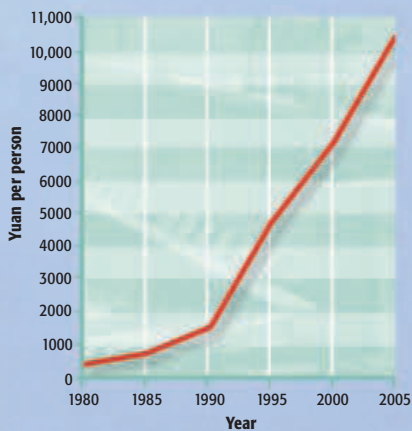


sewing machine; but by the 1990s, they aspired to the “Eight Bigs”—a color television, a refrigerator, a stereo, a camera, a motorbike, a set of furniture, a washing machine, and an electric fan. By 2005 China had overtaken the United States in sales of televisions and cellular phones.

Gap between rich and poor

The transition to a free market caused massive social disruption. Corruption was rampant and a wide gulf opened between the winners and losers in the new economy. While successful Chinese businessmen drove around in Mercedes, millions of people in rural areas were subsisting on less than \$1 a day, and pay for factory workers was pitifully low. Some 150 million Chinese peasants



China's GDP takes a giant leap

China's level of economic output rose in the 1980s but took off spectacularly in the 1990s as the pace of economic reform quickened. There were fears the economy might “overheat,” causing high inflation.

The Three Gorges Dam

Spanning the Yangzi River, the world's largest hydroelectric river dam, when fully operational, will provide power and improve flood control. Its social costs included relocating a million people.



Tourism in China

In 2005, the number of foreign tourists (excluding overseas Chinese) visiting China was 20 million. By 2020 it may be the world's most popular destination.



2008 Beijing Olympics

China has enthusiastically embraced the opportunity to showcase its great achievements. “One World, One Dream” is the Games' motto.

were displaced from the land, roaming the country in search of work. Many migrated to China's cities; others went abroad, making China one of the world's major sources of illegal migrant workers. Urban unemployment also soared as the government struggled to reduce the vast workforce relying on state employment. By the first decade of the 21st century, jobs in the state sector were disappearing at a rate of around 10 million a year.

Into the future

Deng Xiaoping died in 1997, the last Chinese leader of the heroic generation of the Long March. His successor, Jiang Zemin, reaffirmed communist rule, asserting that the Party had always represented the interests of the Chinese people. Yet the regime was threatened by the desire for Western-style freedoms among educated, well-to-do dissidents

and by the mass discontent of workers suffering from poverty and insecurity.

The government's trump card was its assertion of national pride. Prestige events, such as the launch of China's first crewed space flight in 2004 and the staging of the Olympic Games in Beijing in 2008—and an increasingly assertive foreign policy—appealed to most Chinese, who looked forward to their country being recognized as a major world power in the century ahead.

If growth rates continue as they are, China will become the world's largest economy, overtaking the United States in about 2030.

HARMING THE PLANET

Rapid economic growth in China has been accompanied by severe **environmental damage**.

POPULATION GROWTH

Since 1980, the Chinese government has exercised a “**one-child**” policy. Despite this, China's population is expected to stabilize at 1.5 billion by 2050.

CHINESE MOONSHOT

A crewed Chinese moon landing is projected for 2020 at the latest.

City of the future

Shanghai is the ninth-largest city in the world. The city's futuristic novelties include what will be the world's tallest building, the 101-story Shanghai World Financial Center (seen below at an early stage of construction), the Oriental Pearl TV Tower, and the first commercial “maglev” railroad—hovering over magnetic rails, the train can reach 268 mph (431 km/h).

